

Laura Diaz-Villaquiran

Atlanta, GA

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EDUCATION

Master of Science in Geographic Information Science & Technology, Georgia Institute of Technology, August 2023.

B.A. in Anthropology, Summa Cum Laude, Georgia State University, January 2020.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Geographic Information Systems (GIS) and remote sensing; environmental and spatial justice; housing affordability; energy efficiency and energy diplomacy; public health and applied anthropology; participatory and community-based research; Latin American studies, cultural heritage preservation and cultural resource management

HONORS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

Georgia State Foundation Scholarship (\$150)

International Education Fee Scholarship for Study Abroad, Georgia State University (\$1000)

HOPE Scholarship for University System of Georgia Tuition (2016-2019)

Semifinalist Jack Kent Cooke Foundation Undergraduate Transfer Scholarship (2018)

President's List (Fall 2018, Fall 2019)

Dean's List (2012-2019)

GRANTS

Georgia Department of Natural Resources

Environmental Protection Division

Tire Grant (2025)

\$237,000

08/08/2024 - 09/30/2024

Role: Grant Writer

Whole Kids Foundation (2021-2022)

\$3,000

08/27/2021-07/09/2022

Role: Project Coordinator

National Wildlife Federation Eco-School grant

\$1,000

10/04/2021-07/09/2022

Role: Project Coordinator

WORK EXPERIENCE

Senior Research Associate, Southeast Energy Efficiency Alliance (Fall 2023-Present)

Responsibilities: Conducts geospatial analysis of energy metrics and their relationship with sociodemographic and housing factors using ArcGIS Pro, Tableau, R, SQL, and Python. Applies research skills to glean insights into the impact of energy infrastructures, policies, and programs on Southeastern communities. Maintains cross-organizational data workflows using GitHub. Designs and implements participatory research initiatives. Project Coordinator, *Towards Equitable Electric Mobility (TEEM) Community of Practice*, Virginia.

Spatial Data Analyst Intern, Georgia Tech's Center for Quality Growth & Regional Development (Summer 2023)

Responsibilities: Appointed by Dr. Arthi Rao to provide professional-level research and evaluation of projects at Georgia Tech's Center for Quality Growth and Regional Development. Responsible for geospatial data analysis. Analyzed Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF) data to identify trends, performance indicators, and disparities in program outcomes during the COVID-19 pandemic.

FoodCorps Service Member, the International Rescue Committee in Atlanta (Fall 2020-Summer 2022)

Responsibilities: Public service position leveraging food access in a refugee-immigrant community. Taught children in grades K-5 about food and nutrition. Integrated Next Generation Science Standards into hands-on, place based lessons in the school garden. Built strong, collaborative relationships with teachers, families, and school administrators. Applied and secured grant funding for school garden projects, obtained the Whole Kids Foundation and the National Wildlife Federation Eco-School grants. Developed garden sustainability plans. Maintained and expanded school garden infrastructure, including composting and rainwater catchment systems.

Research Assistant, Georgia State University (Spring 2019-Fall 2019)

Responsibilities: Appointed by Dr. Jeffrey Glover in 2019 to lead the database management and digital archival of the historic MARTA transit archaeological collection in Atlanta, GA. Organized and digitized site notes, field notes, artifact photographs, and historical records pertaining to the Civil War/Reconstruction Era (1860-1880), the Victorian Era (1880-1930), and the Great Depression (1930-1950).

See: <https://martaphoenixproject.gsuanthropology.com/>

PRESENTATIONS

"Exploring the Multiple Dimensions of Energy Affordability and Why It Matters," National Energy and Utility Affordability Conference, Summer 2025.

"Mapping Vulnerabilities: Projected Extreme Heat Risk for Southern Mobile Home Residents," North American Cartographic Society Conference, Fall 2024.

"Exploring Energy Burdens Across the United States," National Energy and Utility Affordability

Conference, Summer 2024.

“Exploring the Dietary Proclivities of Neanderthals Using Dental Microwear,” Poster Presentation at the Georgia State Undergraduate Research Conference, Spring 2019.

Conference Panels Organized and Chaired

“The Unseen Stories of Housing, Health, and Energy in Atlanta,” Panel Moderator at the 12th Annual Atlanta Studies Symposium, Summer 2025.

“Constructing a Shared Vision for an Energy Secure Atlanta,” Panel Moderator at the 11th Annual Atlanta Studies Symposium, Spring 2024.

Conference Papers

“Black and Indigenous Midwifery in Abya Yala: Ancestral Healing & Departure from the Master Discourse,” Paper Presentation at Georgia State’s Students Promoting Engagement and Knowledge Through Activism Symposium, Spring 2019.

“Addressing the ‘Complexity Tax’ in Weatherization Assistance Programs,” American Council for an Energy-Efficient Economy - Summer Study Proceedings, Summer 2026.

“Powering Purpose: How Energy Efficiency Strengthens Nonprofits and the Communities They Serve,” American Council for an Energy-Efficient Economy - Summer Study Proceedings, Summer 2026.

“Investigating Equity in Energy Code Compliance,” American Council for an Energy-Efficient Economy - Summer Study Proceedings, Summer 2026.

“Quantifying Regional Economics and Infrastructure Variations using Geospatial and Machine Learning Statistical Analysis,” American Council for an Energy-Efficient Economy - Summer Study Proceedings, Summer 2026.

PUBLICATIONS

“Room to Breathe: Lessons from Atlanta’s First Healthy Housing Program,” Southeast Energy Efficiency Alliance Publication, Fall 2024.

“Exploring the Dietary Proclivities of Neanderthals Using Dental Microwear,” Honors Thesis, Georgia State University, Fall 2019.

Selected Writing - Southeast Energy Efficiency Alliance

“Energy Burden in Mississippi.” Fall 2025 ([link](#))

“Public EV Charging Stations in the Commonwealth.” Fall 2025 ([link](#))

“Hot Spot Analysis: Home Insurance Premiums in the Southeast.” Spring 2025 ([link](#))

“Energy Burden in Tribal Nations.” Fall 2024 ([link](#))

“Power Outages in Puerto Rico.” Fall 2024 ([link](#))

“Change in Residential Building Permits, 2018–2023.” Summer 2024 ([link](#))

“Where Are Southern Mobile Home Residents at Risk of Extreme Heat?” Spring 2024 ([link](#))
“Redlining and Tree Canopy.” Spring 2024 ([link](#))

TECHNICAL EXPERIENCE

Data synthesis and geospatial data analytics

Proficiency working with Excel, Python, R, SQL, ArcGIS Pro, ERDAS Imagine & GitHub

Database management using Omeka

Project Management

Demonstrated professionalism in a multi-cultural contexts

LANGUAGES

Spanish, native speaker (advanced: reading, writing, conversation)

English, fluent (advanced: reading, writing, conversation)

French, basic proficiency